appeared postured to respond quickly to any conflict, but as would be shown, it lacked the depth to maintain a long campaign. The US Pacific Fleet provided the main naval presence in the region, composed of the US Third and Seventh Fleets. With the USS *Gerald R. Ford*, the US Navy's newest aircraft carrier, homeported in Yokosuka, Japan, the US Seventh Fleet had twenty-two ships in Asian waters—including two cruisers, eight guided-missile destroyers (DDGs), four nuclear-powered attack submarines, and an amphibious assault ship—with another forty available based in Hawaii and the Pacific Coast of the United States.[18] Third Fleet forces, drawn from California, Washington, and Hawaii, provided the potential of another two active carriers, with one hundred forty airplanes and ten more submarines.[19] The continental-based US naval forces faced a two-week transit to Japan and three weeks to the Strait of Malacca, while those in Hawaii were a week away from US bases in Japan. Added to the naval forces were the airplanes of the Pacific Air Forces, based at Anderson Air Force Base in Guam and Kadena, Yokota, and Misawa air bases in Japan (the South Korea–based air force squadrons remained detailed for peninsular defense). These roughly three hundred aircraft included two squadrons of F-35s and F-22s, with the remainder being older F-15s and F-16s.[20]

III. The Gray Rhino: September 8–9, 2025

The Littoral War began with a series of accidental encounters in the skies and waters near Scarborough Shoal, in the South China Sea.[21] (See figure 3 for a map of the theater of operations.) Beijing had effectively taken control of the shoal, long a point of contention between China and the Philippines, in 2012.[22] After Philippines president Rodrigo Duterte, who had steadily moved Manila toward China during the late 2010s, was impeached and removed from office, the Philippines' new president moved to reassert Manila's claim to the shoal, including sending coastal patrol boats into waters near the contested territory during the summer of 2025. When armed People's Armed Forces Maritime Militia (PAFMM)